

Empirical Study on the Relationship Between Subjective Well-being of Employees and Social Performance in Social Enterprises

1st Zhong Wang

Hunan University

School of Business

Changsha, China

wangzhonghc@foxmail.com

2nd Ziyi Bai

Hunan University

School of Business

Changsha, China

baizi2012@126.com

Abstract—Social enterprises are emerging enterprises that adopt commercial methods to solve social problems. However, previous studies have not studied the impact of employee characteristics on organizational performance. Under the background of China, this paper use 52 social enterprises and 270 employees as samples to verify the relationship between emotional commitment and subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises and social performance of enterprises by using multilevel structural equation model (MSEM). The study found that: life satisfaction and emotional balance, have a significant role in promoting affective commitment, and also have a significant role in promoting social performance of enterprises; affective commitment plays a mediating role between life satisfaction, emotional balance and social performance of enterprises.

Key words—Subjective Well-being, Social Performance, Affective Commitment, Social Enterprises

I. INTRODUCTION

In recent years, social entrepreneurship has been gradually rising in China [1]. Social entrepreneurship is an entrepreneurship activity which considers both economic and social benefits and solves social problems in a commercial way [2]. Social enterprise is an essential carrier of social entrepreneurship, which plays an important role in solving social problems. Social performance is an important indicator to measure the development of social enterprises [3]. Therefore, researches on improving the social performance of enterprises has been increasingly drawing the attention of social entrepreneurs.

Because of the particularity of social enterprises, the performance of social enterprises is different from that of commercial enterprises. It consists of two dimensions:

economic performance and social performance [4]. The economic performance is the economic income created by enterprises, which is no different from commercial enterprises; while social performance is the social value created by enterprises. As social enterprises play an increasingly important role in promoting economic development and social progress, it is of great practical value to explore the mechanism of improving the performance of social enterprises. Few existing studies on the influencing factors of social performance are found and existing works focused on the organizational level [5] and the individual characteristics of social entrepreneurs [6]. Only little number of researches focused on the impact of employee characteristics on social performance of enterprises.

Subjective well-being is a holistic evaluation on the quality of personal life based on their own standards. It is a comprehensive psychological index to measure personal life quality with two dimensions of life satisfaction and emotional balance [7]. Life satisfaction is the subjective evaluation of the quality of life, and emotional balance is the emotions that a person experiences in life [8]. With increasing attention from the public to well-being and the development of positive psychology in recent years, well-being has become a hot topic in organizational research. Thereby, research on employees' subjective well-being has been gradually increasing. A number of studies performed empirical analysis on the antecedents of subjective well-being from the aspects of individual characteristics [9], income [10] and work situation [11], but there are relatively few studies on the outcome variables of subjective well-being. Much fewer studies focused on the influence of employees' subjective well-being on the organization from the view of organization.

In this work, the authors propose a cross-level intermediary model of the subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises to the social performance of enterprises, and use affective commitment as a cross-level intermediary variable to explore the mechanism of the impact of subjective well-being of employees on the social performance of enterprises. It is hoped to deepen and expand the relevant research on the performance of social enterprises and provide enlightenment and reference for the human resource management of social enterprise managers in practice.

II. THEORETICAL BACKGROUND AND RESEARCH HYPOTHESIS

A. Subjective Well-being of Social Enterprise Employees and Social Performance of Enterprises

Many studies have shown that people with a high level of well-being can achieve success in many areas of life, such as marriage [12], income [13], and health [14-15]. Lyubomirsky believes that as an important indicator of subjective well-being, positive emotions are essential factors for success [16]. Recent studies have introduced the discussion of subjective well-being into the field of human resources management. These works mainly focused on employees' organizational commitment, job performance, turnover intention and other outcome variables. It has been confirmed that well-being is closely related to these outcome variables [17]. At present, academic research on subjective well-being and performance mostly focus on the relationship between subjective well-being and job performance. Employees with higher subjective well-being will expand social resources, improve creative thinking, work comprehensively and optimistically, which can help employees seize opportunities [18]. Russell's study shows that subjective well-being of employees has a significant positive impact on job performance [19]. Employees with higher level of subjective well-being are more active in work and can achieve better job performance, while negative emotions have a negative impact on employees' job performance. Enterprises are composed of employees. Only the improvement of employees' work performance can lead to the improvement of enterprise's performance. The previous discussion on performance mostly focused on commercial enterprises. However, social enterprises pay more attention to the social benefits brought by enterprises when compared to commercial enterprises. Employees with higher level of well-being tend to have higher

agreeableness and empathy [20], which help to improve the social performance of enterprises. Based on the analysis above, two hypotheses are proposed and stated as follow:

H1a: The life satisfaction of employees in social enterprises has a positive impact on the social performance of enterprises.

H1b: The emotional balance of employees in social enterprises has a positive impact on the social performance of enterprises.

B. Subjective Well-being and Affective Commitment of Employees in Social Enterprises

Affective commitment refers to employees' recognition of organizational values, their commitment to organizational goals and their emotional attachment to the organization [21]. It is embodied in employees actively publicizing the organization to others, maintaining the image and reputation of the organization, making efforts for the development of the organization, feeling proud as members of the organization, and having high level of trust and loyalty to the organization. Affective commitment, sustained commitment and normative commitment constitute organizational commitment. Sustained commitment is a commitment that employees want to continually get salaries and benefits from organization and stay in the organization. Normative commitment refers to the behavior that employees believe loyalty to the organization conforms to social norms and stay in the organization [21]. Compared with normative commitment and continuous commitment, affective commitment can better reflect the essential characteristics of employees' working attitude [22], and it is the core of the three dimensions of organizational commitment [21].

In recent years, researchers have studied the influencing factors of affective commitment related to individual work, including person-organization fit, career growth needs, job diversity, job satisfaction, etc. The research object generally comes from commercial enterprises or government agencies. Cicekli's research shows that development opportunities and recognition are predictors of organizational commitment [23]. Kooij found that person-organization fit was positively correlated with affective commitment over time [24]. Oyinlade found that work structure is an important predictor of affective commitment [25]. Top found that one aspect of life satisfaction - job satisfaction (two dimensions of operational procedures and communication) and

organizational trust are important predictors of employees' affective commitment [26]. Abu-Shamaa also confirmed that job satisfaction had a positive impact on organizational commitment, and job engagement had a positive impact on affective commitment [27]. Employees with higher subjective well-being have more optimistic attitude and can see more positive aspects of their organizations. Brunetto found that with the improvement in well-being level, employees' organizational commitment increases correspondingly, and well-being can predict their affective commitment better than job satisfaction [28]. Meyer's meta-analysis shows that negative emotions in the emotional balance of subjective well-being can negatively affect the affective commitment. Life satisfaction and emotional balance have significant effects on affective commitment [29]. As a special enterprise group, social enterprises have the characteristics of general enterprises. Accordingly, the following hypotheses are put forward:

H2a: Life satisfaction of employees in social enterprises has a positive impact on affective commitment.

H2b: Emotional Balance of employees in social enterprises has a positive impact on affective commitment.

C. The Mediating Role of Affective Commitment

As discussed previously, the subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises has a direct impact on affective commitment. Employees with high subjective well-being tend to have an optimistic attitude, which leads to higher affective commitment. Also, affective commitment connects employees and organizations [30], and unifies the goals and values of employees and organizations. Employees with high affective commitment will have a sense of belonging to the organization, desire to remain in the organization, are willing to pursue organizational goals [31], hope that the organization will succeed and are proud of the organization [32]. The higher employee's affective commitment, the higher job involvement. Atmojo [33] and Edwards [34] found that organizational commitment has a significant impact on employee performance, which is consistent with previous studies by many researches. Jain found that strong affective commitment can promote organizational performance [35].

Therefore, the indirect relationship between the subjective well-being of employees and the social performance of enterprises is clear. Employees' subjective well-being and

affective commitment is at the individual level, while social performance of enterprises stays at the organizational level. The research method and application of this 1-1-2 model have been used in some works in recent years [36]. It is believed that employees with higher level of subjective well-being can work comprehensively and optimistically and have higher affective commitment to the organization. This kind of affective commitment will motivate them to take organizational goals as their responsibility and increase their involvement in organizational activities, thereby promoting the improvement of organizational performance. Accordingly, the following hypotheses are put forward:

H3a: Employees' affective commitment in social enterprises plays a mediating role between life satisfaction and social performance in enterprises.

H3b: Employees' affective commitment in social enterprises plays a mediating role between emotional balance and social performance in enterprises.

To sum up, the research model of this work is shown in Figure 1.

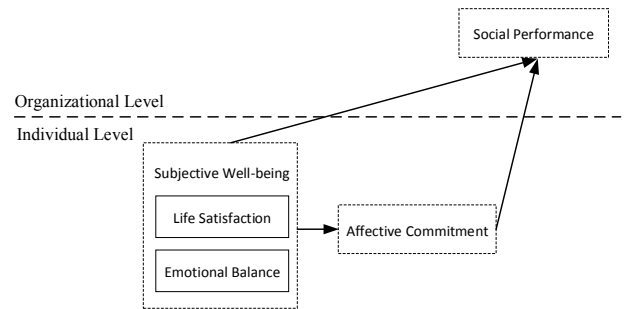


FIGURE 1 RESEARCH MODEL

III. RESEARCH DESIGN

A. Research Object and Procedure

In this work, convenience sampling method and snowball sampling are used to select social enterprises in Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Changsha, Chengdu, Nanjing and other places to conduct a questionnaire survey. Since Chinese social enterprises start late, most of them are in the initial stage. Studying social enterprises in the initial stage is more instructive to the development of social enterprises in China. Therefore, the social enterprises selected in this study are all social enterprises in the initial stage, which have been established for no more than 8 years. In order to control the homologous deviation, this study collects data from two

sources: top managers and employees. Top managers evaluate the social performance of enterprises, and randomly select employees (including long-term volunteers) to fill in employee questionnaires. Subjective well-being and emotions commitment are evaluated according to their own situation.

Before the formal survey, a pre-survey was conducted by inviting graduate students, alumni and MBA College to fill in the questionnaire. According to the feedback from the subjects, the errors and ambiguous options in the questionnaire were corrected accordingly. In the formal survey, the participants have been explained that the survey is only used for academic research, and the content of the questionnaire is strictly confidential, to ensure that the participants to be free of any concerns and complete the questionnaire according only to the their actual situation.

The survey lasted three months. A total of 93 manager questionnaires and 402 employee questionnaires were sent out. After filtering out invalid questionnaires, 52 questionnaires from managers and 270 questionnaires from employee were obtained, with an effective rate of 65.05%.

B. Variable measurement

Maturity scale is used in this work to measure subjective well-being, affective commitment and social performance of enterprises, to guarantee the reliability and validity of the measurement tools.

1) Subjective Well-being

The life satisfaction scale is developed by Diener [37], which contains five items such as “My life is very close to my ideal life in many aspects” and was filled out by social enterprise employees.

The emotional balance scale is developed by Campbell [38], which contains eight items consisting of 16 words such as “Pain - Happiness” and was filled out by social enterprise employees.

2) Affective Commitment

The Affective commitment scale is developed by Meyer & Allen [21], which contains six items, such as “In this organization, I feel like a member of a large family” and was filled out by social enterprise employees.

3) Social Performance of Enterprises

The social performance of enterprises is developed by Liu [39], including five items, such as “the organization benefits

more and more people” and was filled out by the managers of social enterprises.

The variables above were measured by Likert 5 scale, of which 1 represented “very inconsistent” and 5 represented “completely consistent”.

4) Control Variable

Based on previous studies and the contents of this study, at the individual level, gender, age, education level and length of work (i.e., the length of time an individual works in the organization) were selected as control variables

TABLE 1 SAMPLE DISTRIBUTION AT INDIVIDUAL LEVEL

Variable	Category	Amount	Ratio
N=270			
Gender	Male (=1)	116	42.96%
	Female (=2)	154	57.04%
Age	≤30 (=1)	79	29.26%
	31-40 (=2)	125	46.30%
	41-50 (=3)	54	20.00%
	≥51 (=4)	12	4.44%
Education level	High school and below (=1)	23	8.52%
	Junior college (=2)	64	23.70%
	Regular college (=3)	138	51.11%
	Master and above (=4)	45	16.67%
working seniority	≤1 (=1)	45	16.67%
seniority	2-3 (=2)	139	51.48%
	4-5 (=3)	70	25.93%
	≥6 (=4)	16	5.92%

TABLE 2 SAMPLE DISTRIBUTION AT ORGANIZATIONAL LEVEL

Variable	Category	Amount	Ratio
N=52			
Enterprise size (person)	≤10 (=1)	10	19.23%
	11-50 (=2)	25	48.08%
	51-100 (=3)	4	7.69%
	101-300 (=4)	5	9.62%
	≥301 (=5)	8	15.38%
Establishment life	2 years and below (=1)	22	42.31%
	3-5 years (=2)	20	38.46%
	6-8 years (=3)	10	19.23%

C. Statistical Analysis Method

In this paper, the multilevel structural equation model (MSEM) is used to test the proposed conceptual model. Traditional cross-level models often use hierarchical linear

Model (HLM) for analysis, but this method cannot deal with models whose result variables is in high-level. Compared with HLM, using MSEM to analyze the mediation effect can consider the error and not confuse the intra-group and inter-group effects of level-1 variables on other variables [40]. It can not only effectively reduce the bias of mediation effect estimation, but also perform better on the 95% confidence interval coverage index of mediation effect [41-42]. Preacher put forward the steps of checking the cross-level model of level-1 to level-2, and compiled the Mplus program, which has been used by many researchers in recent years [36]. This method is also used to test the hypothesis in this paper.

This study belongs to a 1-1-2 multilevel model, in which subjective well-being (including life satisfaction and emotional balance) and affective commitment belong to level-1, and social performance belongs to level-2. Firstly, R-language is used to test the inter-group variability index ICC (1), intra-group variability index ICC (2) and intra-group consistency index Rwg. For life satisfaction, the ICC (1) was 0.41, ICC (2) was 0.78, Rwg was 0.86; for emotional balance, the ICC (1) was 0.51, ICC (2) was 0.85, Rwg was 0.86; for affective commitment, the ICC (1) was 0.40, ICC (2) was 0.77 and Rwg was 0.84, all of them met the standard values of ICC (1) over 0.12, ICC (2) over 0.7 and Rwg over 0.7. Therefore, the MSEM method is suitable for testing the hypothesis in this paper.

In this work, SPSS 20.0 software is used to calculate the mean value and standard deviation of variables, and Mplus 7 software is used to test the model by maximum likelihood robust estimator (MLR).

IV. EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS

A. Reliability and Validity

Reliability refers to the possibility of obtaining consistent results when repeated measurements are made on the same

subject with the same measuring tool. The scale selected in this paper has good reliability. The Cronbach's α coefficient of all variables is larger than 0.7. Among them, α coefficient of life satisfaction is 0.708, α coefficient of emotional balance is 0.888, and α coefficient of affective commitment is 0.888, α coefficient of affective commitment is 0.743, α coefficient of social performance of social enterprises is 0.842.

Convergence validity analysis assessed the degree of correlation among measurements of the same concept. Based on average variance extraction (AVE) analysis, AVE of all variables was larger than 0.5. AVE of life satisfaction is 0.976, AVE of emotional balance is 0.980, AVE of affective commitment is 0.868, AVE of social performance is 0.527.

In this paper, Mplus 7 was used to for confirmatory factor analysis to test the discriminatory validity of variables. Since social performance belongs to the organizational level and is filled out by managers of social enterprises, there is no need for factor analysis with other concepts. The results show that the three-factor model composed of life satisfaction, emotional balance and affective commitment fits best ($\chi^2=180.556$, $df=149$, $\chi^2/df=1.21$, $RMSEA=0.064$, $CFI=0.925$, $TLI=0.914$), which shows that the constructs have good discriminatory validity.

B. Descriptive Statistics and Correlation Analysis

In this paper, descriptive statistics and correlation analysis of all variables are carried out with SPSS 20.0 software. The results of mean value, standard deviation and correlation coefficients of all variables are shown in Table 3. The results show that life satisfaction is positively correlated with affective commitment and social performance; emotional balance is positively correlated with affective commitment and social performance; affective commitment is positively correlated with social performance.

TABLE 3 DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS AND CORRELATION COEFFICIENTS OF VARIABLES

Variable	Mean value	Standard deviation	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Individual level									
1. Gender	1.57	0.50	1						
2. Age	2.00	0.82	-0.159**	1					
3. Education level	2.76	0.83	0.028	0.195**	1				
4. Working seniority	2.21	0.79	0.109	0.203**	0.101	1			
5. Life Satisfaction	3.53	0.79	0.004	0.032	-0.105	0.166**	1		

6. Emotional balance	3.22	0.83	0.016	0.056	0.142*	0.098	0.403**	1	
7. Affective commitment	3.36	0.75	0.001	0.093	0.129*	0.021	0.303**	0.437**	1
Organizational level									
1. Enterprise size	2.56	1.36	1						
2. Establishment life	1.76	0.74	0.212**	1					
3. Social Performance	3.69	0.91	0.061	0.087	1				

Note: N=270, * means $p < 0.05$, ** means $p < 0.01$, *** means $p < 0.001$

C. Hypothesis Test

This study examines the cross-level mediating effect of affective commitment on the subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises and the social performance of enterprises by using a multilevel structural equation model. Mplus 7 is used to analyze the 1-1-2 multilevel model across layers. Table 4 shows the hypothesis test results for the impact of two dimensions of subjective well-being (life satisfaction and emotional balance) on the social performance of enterprises. The results show that both life satisfaction ($\beta=0.634$, $p < 0.001$) and emotional balance ($\beta=0.468$, $p < 0.001$) can significantly improve social performance of social enterprises, thereby the hypothesis H1a and H1b are supported; Table 5 shows the hypothesis test results of the influence of two dimensions of subjective well-being on affective commitment. The results show that both life satisfaction ($\beta=0.514$, $p < 0.001$) and emotional balance ($\beta=0.632$, $p < 0.001$) can significantly enhance affective commitment, thereby the hypotheses H2a and H2b are supported.

TABLE 4 THE REGRESSION ANALYSIS OF SOCIAL ENTERPRISE EMPLOYEE'S SUBJECTIVE WELL-BEING ON SOCIAL PERFORMANCE OF ENTERPRISES

	Social performance			
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Individual level				
Life Satisfaction	0.634***	0.183		
Emotional balance			0.468***	0.124
Organizational level				
Enterprise size	0.054	0.095	-0.030	0.139
Establishment life	0.168	0.129	0.196	0.136

Note: * means $p < 0.05$, ** means $p < 0.01$, *** means $p < 0.001$, the same below.

TABLE 5 THE REGRESSION ANALYSIS OF EMPLOYEES' SUBJECTIVE WELL-BEING ON AFFECTIVE COMMITMENT IN SOCIAL ENTERPRISES

Variable	Affective commitment			
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Gender	-0.003	0.068	0.005	0.064
Age	0.073	0.094	0.072	0.085
Education level	0.193	0.104	0.027	0.107
Working seniority	-0.118	0.108	-0.080	0.099
Life Satisfaction	0.514***	0.129		
Emotional balance			0.632 ***	0.105

TABLE 6 ANALYSIS OF INTERLAYER MEDIATION EFFECT

Mediation variable path	Mediation effect		Confidence	
	value		interval (95%)	
	Estimate	SE	Lower	Upper
Life Satisfaction → Affective commitment → Social performance	0.311*	0.150	0.016	0.606
Emotional balance → Affective commitment → Social performance	0.393*	0.165	0.069	0.665

Table 6 shows the cross-level mediating effect of affective commitment between subjective well-being and social performance in social enterprises. The results show that: (1) The mediating effect value of affective commitment between life satisfaction and social performance is 0.311 (SE = 0.150, $P < 0.05$), and the 95% confidence interval is (0.016, 0.606), excluding 0. This indicates that the mediating effect of affective commitment between life satisfaction and social performance of enterprises is significant, and the hypothesis H3a is supported. (2) The mediating effect value of affective commitment between emotional balance and social performance of enterprises is 0.393 (SE = 0.165, $P < 0.05$), and the 95% confidence interval is (0.069, 0.665), excluding 0. This indicates that affective commitment has a significant mediating effect between emotional balance and social

performance of enterprises, and the hypothesis H3b is supported.

V. CONCLUSION

A. Research Conclusion

This paper introduces the emotional commitment as a cross-level mediating variable at the individual level. With a questionnaire survey from 52 executives and 270 employees, the analysis shows that two dimensions of subjective well-being, life satisfaction and emotional balance, have a significant impact on affective commitment as well as social performance of enterprises. Emotional commitment mediates the positive correlation between subjective well-being and social performance of enterprises. The conclusion of the study has certain enlightenment significance for the development of social enterprises both in theory and in practice.

B. Research Meaning

The theoretical contributions of this work are stated as follow:

This work expands the research on the influencing factors of social performance of enterprises. Most of the existing studies focus on the measurement of social performance. Few studies on the influencing factors of social performance only stay at the organizational level or on the individual characteristics of social entrepreneurs. No researcher has paid attention to the impact of employee level on the social performance of enterprises. In this paper, the multi-level structural equation model is used to study the mechanism of the subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises on the social performance of enterprises, to verify the cross-level mediation effect of emotional commitment and to provide a new perspective for the study of the factors affecting the social performance of enterprise.

This work enriches the related research on subjective well-being. Most of the existing studies on subjective well-being of employees are from the perspective of maintaining a good employment relationship. Only few researchers have confirmed that subjective well-being of employees in commercial enterprises can improve personal performance. This paper extends the study of subjective well-being of employees to the field of social enterprises and puts forward that subjective well-being of employees in social enterprises has a positive impact on social performance of enterprises.

This paper also broadens the scope of research on subjective well-being.

This study also has a certain practical significance for social enterprise management. Based on the results of this study, the following enlightenments are obtained: Firstly, this paper emphasizes the importance of employee subjective well-being, and proves that employee subjective well-being promotes the social performance of enterprises through empirical analysis. The results suggest that social enterprises should choose employees with higher subjective well-being when recruiting employees or long-term volunteers. It helps to improve employees' emotional commitment and further improve social performance of enterprises. Secondly, social enterprises should adopt management methods that help to improve employees' well-being in the process of management. For example, to enhance employee's work autonomy and make employees perceive more social supports.

C. Research Limitations and Prospects

While this paper draws some enlightening conclusions through empirical analysis, there are still some limitations in the following aspects:

Firstly, the object of study is social enterprises, which is still in its initial stage in China. At present, the sample size is relatively small. With the further development of social enterprises in China, the sample size should be increased in the future research.

Secondly, data in this paper are cross-sectional data, which cannot reveal the causal relationship between variables. Future researches may consider collecting longitudinal data to explore the causal relationship between variables.

Thirdly, samples selected in this study only come from several cities of China where social enterprises are developing rapidly. The applicability of the conclusions to other cities' social enterprises still need further verification.

Finally, this paper only explores the cross-level mediating effect of emotional commitment between the subjective well-being of employees and the social performance of enterprises. The other two dimensions of organizational commitment (sustained commitment and normative commitment) may also affect the relationship between subjective well-being and social performance of enterprises. This can be explored in further research to improve the mechanism of the relationship

between the subjective well-being of social enterprise employees and performance of enterprises.

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